

Harnessing AI for environmental justice

Principles and practices for civil society



I'm Laura Hilliger

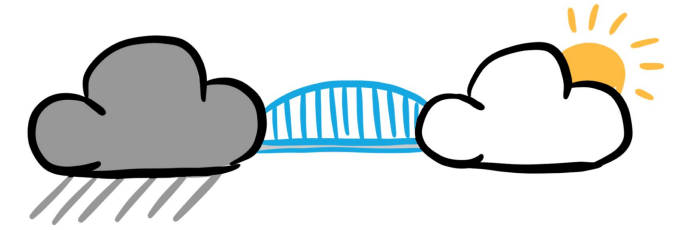
Co-founder of We Are Open Co-op

We Are Open Co-op is a collective of independent thinkers and makers helping charities, ethical companies, government departments and educational institutions with research, strategy, programme design, content, sensemaking and digital transformation.

<https://weareopen.coop>



My career



BRIDGE TO A BETTER WORLD



In the beginning

I nerded out in Yahoo chat rooms and pretended to be a 26 year old surf instructor while living in the Appalachians

2010

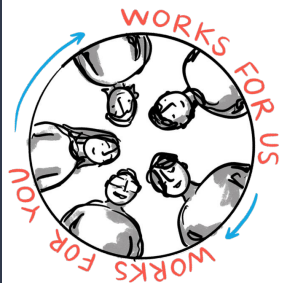
Went to work for the Mozilla Foundation as a creative and educational leader. Wrote my thesis on Web Literacy.

2020

Won the Women in IT Digital Leader of the Year Award for my work bringing open principles to Greenpeace

2005

Taught people multimedia and story stuff at BAVC, UC Berkeley and for companies like Pixar.



2015

Left Mozilla and went to work at Greenpeace International, bringing open source culture and behaviors along with me.

GREENPEACE

2016

Co-founded We Are Open with a couple of my former Mozilla mates.



Since then

Wrote some books, spoke about activism, technology and story and have worked with charities large and small on projects that try to make the world a better place.

Introduction

What we're
discussing
today



Harnessing AI for Environmental Justice

[This research](#), funded by Mozilla and guided by Friends of the Earth unpacks the environmental effects of AI and outlines how activists and campaigners can use AI in ways that align with their values.



Promoting Informed Citizenship in a Connected World

[This paper in the Journal for Media Literacy](#) explores the evolving relationship between media, information, and digital literacy in light of rapid technological advancements, including AI.



Positioning Paper for the United Nations

Presented at the 18th annual Internet Governance forum of the United Nations in October 2023, we contributed to a positioning paper on higher education's role in AI development. [This post outlines our position.](#)

AI Literacy
a project from **WAO**

<https://ailiteracy.fyi>



AI Literacy: A Cross-Sectional Slice of New Literacies

WAO contributed to this response to a UNESCO call for contributions on the "Definition of Algorithm Literacy and Data Literacy". [This post](#) gives an overview and links to the full response.



Deep Dive into the Ethics, Literacy, and Application of AI

[Season 7 of the Tao of WAO](#) focused on AI. With a variety of guests thinking about AI's application in human development, workforce development, the public sector and more, this season picks apart recent AI jargon and offers insight into our collective future.



AI in Open Recognition

We've done some thinking around how to use AI tools for identifying and mapping skills against various frameworks using a custom GPT called ePIC Skills Mapper. [Here's a write up of the workshop](#) we ran at ePIC in November 2024.

About Friends of the Earth



2003

Household Waste & Recycling Act brought doorstep recycling to all UK homes

2018

EU wide ban on the outdoor use of “neonic” pesticides making the countryside safer for over 260 insect species

2021

80% of councils in England have committed to ambitious Climate Action Plans

2022

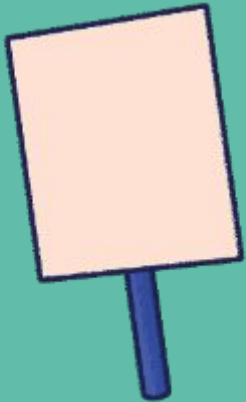
UK Government Net Zero strategy judged unlawful

2008

Climate Change Act which commits the UK to 80% reduction in emissions by 2050

2019

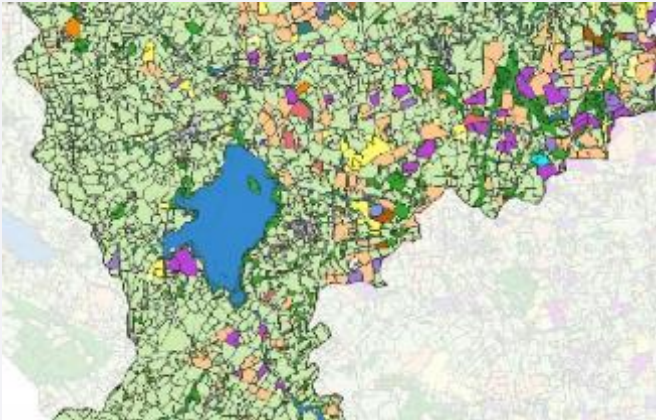
Ministers vote for moratorium on fracking in England



Experiments in AI

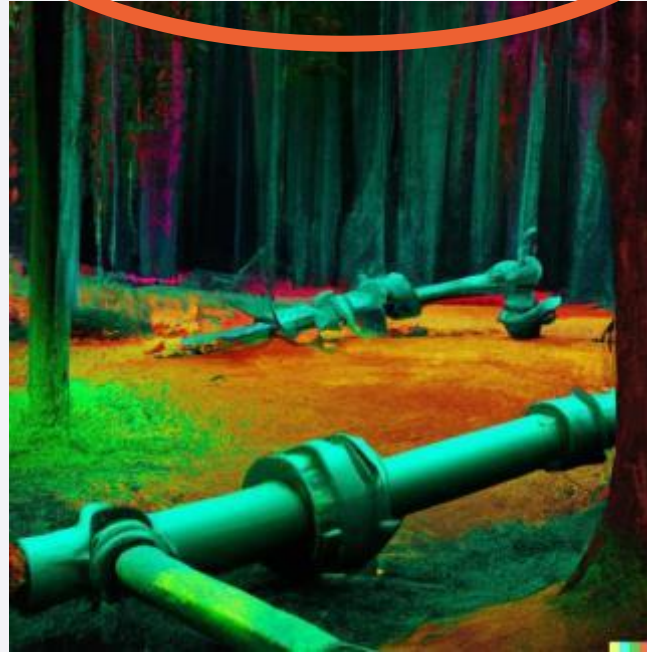
1

Learn what works



2

Future readiness (risk and opportunity)



3

Seeing is believing!



Harnessing AI for environmental justice

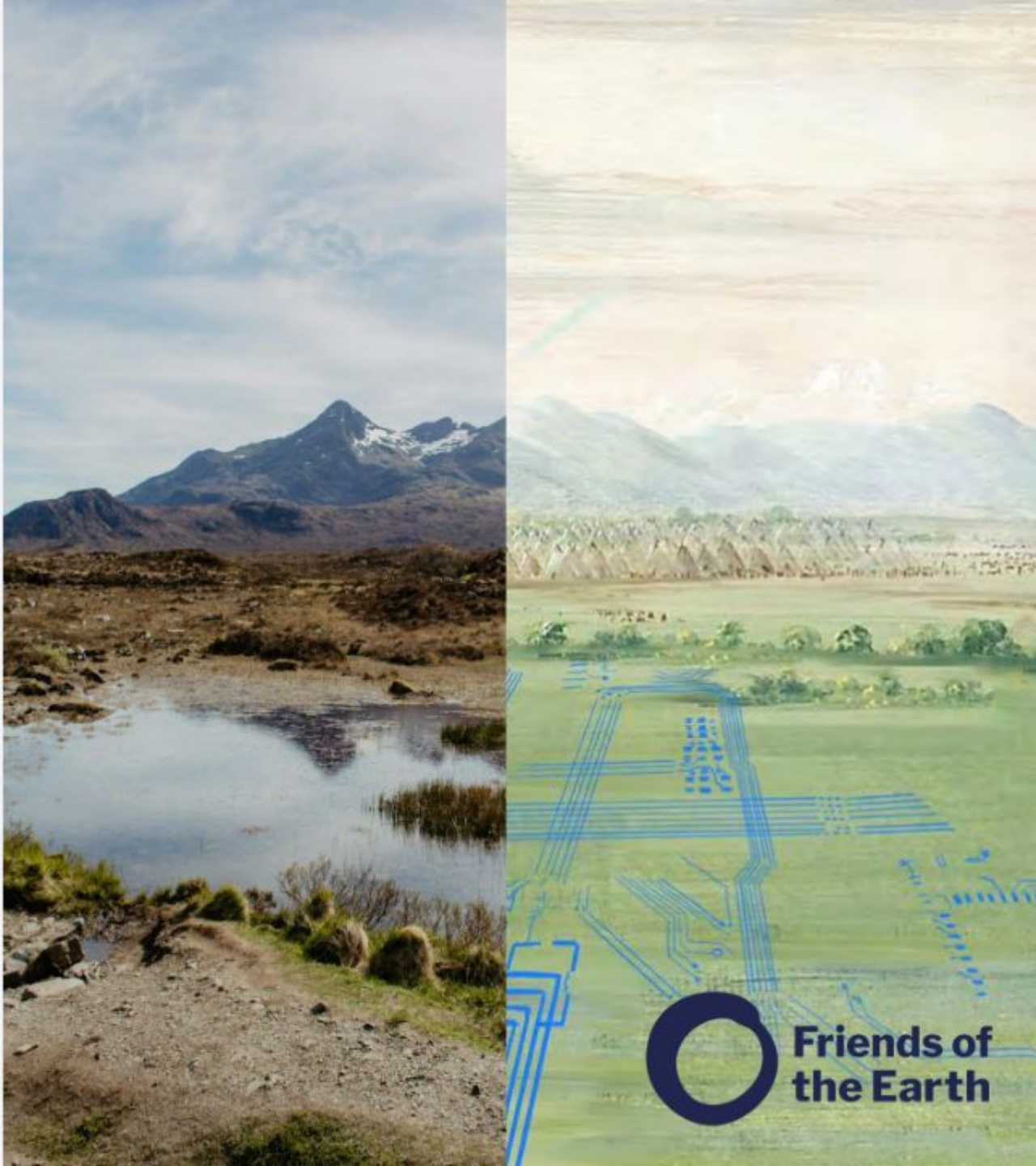
Principles and practices to guide climate justice and digital rights campaigners in the responsible use of AI

Images Left: Cuillin Hills in Scotland, Viktor Löwen. Right: Hanna Barakat + AIxDESIGN & Archival Images of AI / Better Images of AI / Weaving Wires 2 / CC-BY 4.0

**Green Screen
Coalition**



**Friends of
the Earth**



Acknowledgements

Authored by Laura Hilliger and Doug Belshaw,
We Are Open Cooperative

In collaboration with Mary Stevens,
Friends of the Earth

Generously funded by
Green Screen Catalyst Fund

**Read it
here**



**We are at a critical moment for
AI and the climate .**



Behind the headlines

AI's excessive water consumption threatens to drown out its environmental contributions

Published: March 21, 2024 5.26pm GMT

GIZMODO

CLIMATE CHANGE

Leading Denier Think Tank Uses AI Image of Dead Whale and Wind Turbines

The Texas Public Policy Foundation used AI to push a misleading story about renewable energy — a practice that could soon become widespread.

Water shortage fears as Labour's first AI growth zone sited close to new reservoir

First datacentre site proposed seven miles from Abingdon reservoir planned for water-stressed south-east England



Climate Action Against Disinformation

ISSUES NOTE
21 September 2024

Artificial intelligence (AI) end-to-end:

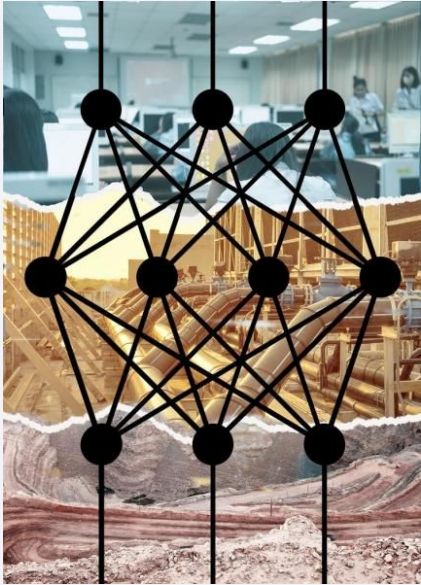
The environmental impact of the full AI life cycle needs to be comprehensively assessed

Donald Trump's inauguration: Which tech leaders attended and who skipped it?



GENERATING A(I) CRISIS: The impact of "generative AI" and machine learning systems on corporate accountability and system decarbonisation

Friends of the Earth



AI must serve people & planet.

Not exploit them.

“[My approach is to] adopt a practice of just enough. Just enough technology, just enough energy consumption, just enough AI to do what we want to do, what we need to do, and no more. I'm just not sure that current forms of AI are suitable for that, so I would encourage resistance, care and critical thinking around any approach to AI.”

(Marcus Berdaut, Creative Producer, The Upsetters)²

7 principles for responsible AI use

1. **Curiosity** around AI creates opportunities for better choices.
2. **Transparency** around usage, data, and algorithms builds trust.
3. **Accountability** Holding tech companies, governments, and each other accountable leads to responsible action.
4. **Inclusivity** Including diverse voices strengthens decision-making around AI.
5. **Sustainability** in AI systems helps reduce environmental impact and protect natural ecosystems.
6. **Community** collaboration in AI is key to planetary resilience.
7. **Intersectionality:** Advocating with an intersectional approach supports humane AI.

7 principles for responsible AI use

1. **Curiosity** around AI creates opportunities for better choices.
2. **Transparency** around usage, data, and algorithms builds trust.
3. **Accountability** Holding tech companies, governments, and each other accountable leads to responsible action.
4. **Inclusivity** Including diverse voices strengthens decision-making around AI.
5. **Sustainability** in AI systems helps reduce environmental impact and protect natural ecosystems.
6. **Community** collaboration in AI is key to planetary resilience.
7. **Intersectionality:** Advocating with an intersectional approach supports humane AI.

Curiosity: key to better choices

Responsible practices

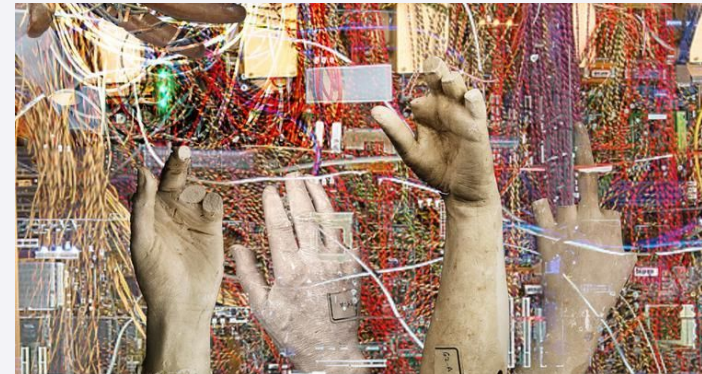
- Encourage curiosity and **open discussions** about AI and the environment
- **Question** the use of AI and advocate for simpler, more sustainable alternatives.
- Consider whether AI is **the right tool** for the task.
- Research and experiment with **independent or open-source** genAI.

Advocating for change

- Campaign for policies that **distinguish** between different types of AI and reduce reliance on energy-intensive options.
- Make the case for a “proportionate” approach, **challenging the narrative** that AI is the only solution.
- **Highlight examples** of communities successfully using AI to solve local problems.

Policy recommendations

- **Advocate** for regulation based on the type of AI in use.
- Encourage AI providers to provide **plain-language explanations** of how their tools work



7 principles for responsible AI use

1. **Curiosity** around AI creates opportunities for better choices.
2. **Transparency** around usage, data, and algorithms builds trust.
3. **Accountability** Holding tech companies, governments, and each other accountable leads to responsible action.
4. **Inclusivity** Including diverse voices strengthens decision-making around AI.
5. **Sustainability** in AI systems helps reduce environmental impact and protect natural ecosystems.
6. **Community** collaboration in AI is key to planetary resilience.
7. **Intersectionality:** Advocating with an intersectional approach supports humane AI.

Accountability: the basis of responsible action

Responsible practices

- Develop and maintain an **organisational AI policy** detailing your choices.
- **Share your policies** openly to help others.
- **Report** against your policies, highlighting where a lack of transparency makes your efforts difficult.
- Find and **work with peers** facing the same challenges.
- **Question suppliers** in the procurement stage of AI services about how they're measuring their impact.

Advocating for change

- Draw attention to the **environmental impacts** of AI, holding organisations and AI companies accountable.
- **Promote holistic frameworks** that assess societal and environmental impacts, highlighting the hidden costs of AI systems.
- **Use examples from** human, labour and digital rights policy and other justice initiatives to establish accountability positions proven to work.

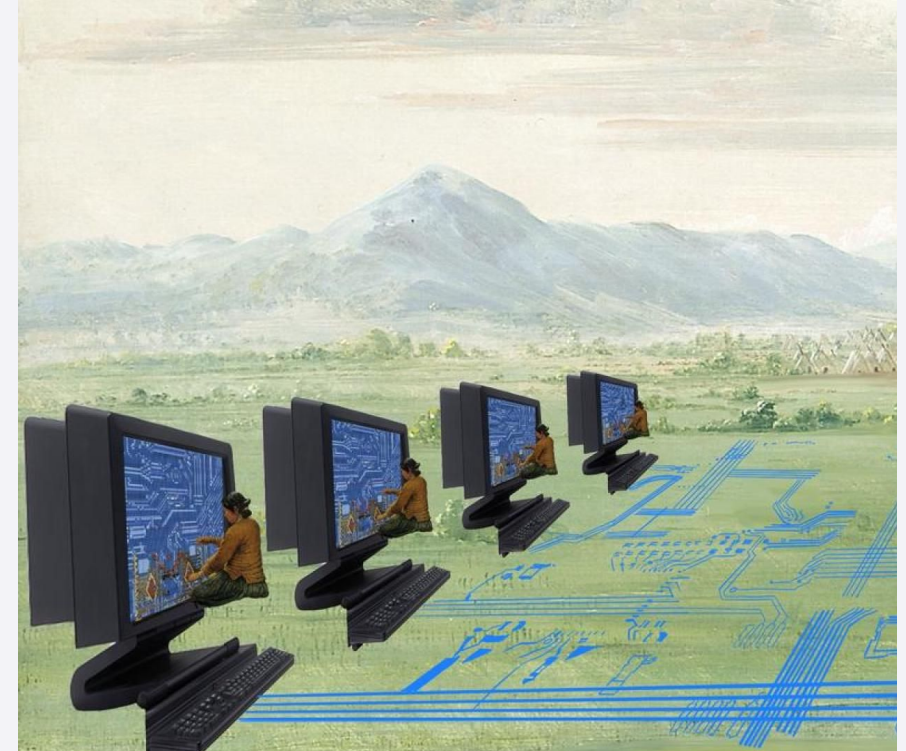
Policy recommendations

- Mandate **independent audits** of AI systems.
- Demand **due diligence** in oversight of AI systems (including 'human-in-the-loop')
- Demand **AI literacy** education.



In summary

- **Stronger regulation**
- **Responsible AI adoption**
- **Community-led AI**



Take the next step

1. Read the report!
2. Start the conversation
(and share your feedback!)
3. Push for 'worthwhile' AI



Thank you

Get in touch! hello@weareopen.coop

